From Start *2* Keys

WASHINGTON · 2026 EDITION

The Homebuyer *Guide*

Your step-by-step plan from renting to getting the keys, with Washington down payment help, loan options and the checklists I give my own clients.

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Tacoma · Pierce County
Seattle · South Sound

START HERE

From start to *keys* in 9 steps

Buying a home is a lot of small, doable steps. Here's the order I walk my clients through, so nothing sneaks up on you.

01 **Get your plan**
Book a free consult. We map your budget, timeline and must-haves.

02 **Take the homebuyer class**
Free and state-certified. It's required for most Washington down payment assistance.

03 **Get pre-approved**
A lender reviews your income, credit and assets and tells you your real number.

04 **Line up down payment help**
See if you qualify for Washington programs (page 4) before you shop.

05 **Shop smart**
Tour homes that fit your numbers and your life. I set up alerts so you see new homes first.

06 **Make a strong offer**
Price, terms and timing that win without overpaying.

07 **Inspection & appraisal**
Protect yourself. Negotiate repairs or credits if needed.

08 **Final loan approval**
Underwriting signs off. Lock your rate, keep your finances steady.

09 **Close & get your keys**
Sign, fund, record. Welcome home.

Typical timeline: 1–3 months to get ready and shop, then about **30–45 days** from accepted offer to keys.

THE MONEY

What it really takes to *buy*

Most buyers need far less than 20% down. Here are the common loan types and their typical minimum down payments.

LOAN TYPE	TYPICAL MINIMUM DOWN	GOOD FIT FOR
FHA	3.5% (with a 580+ credit score)	First-time buyers, lower credit scores, smaller savings
Conventional	3% for many first-time buyers; 5%+ otherwise	Good credit; mortgage insurance can come off later
VA	0%	Eligible veterans, active duty (JBLM!) and some surviving spouses
USDA	0%	Eligible rural and some suburban areas, income limits apply

Plan for these costs too

1–3%
Earnest money
Deposit with your offer. It goes toward your purchase at closing.

2–5%
Closing costs
Lender, title, escrow and prepaid taxes/insurance. Seller credits can help.

$400–$700
Home inspection
Paid upfront. Worth every dollar.

2–3 mo.
Reserves
Savings left after closing for peace of mind.

Ranges are typical estimates, not quotes. Your lender gives exact numbers on your Loan Estimate.

WASHINGTON DOWN PAYMENT HELP

Programs that can cover your *down payment*

These statewide programs from the Washington State Housing Finance Commission (WSHFC) are 0%–low interest second loans with no monthly payment. You repay when you sell, refinance or pay off the home.

PROGRAM	HOW MUCH	KEY POINTS
Home Advantage DPA	Up to 4% of the loan (up to 5% on some conventional loans)	Paired with the Home Advantage mortgage. Income limits apply. No first-time buyer rule.
Opportunity / HomeChoice DPA	Roughly $10,000–$15,000, depending on program	For lower-income buyers; HomeChoice serves buyers with a disability or a household member with a disability.
Covenant Homeownership Program	Up to 20% of the price, capped at $150,000, plus closing costs	First-time buyers who meet income limits and family-history requirements (living in WA before 1968). Funding is limited and the program is under federal review in 2026. Confirm status first.

Your class certificate matters. WSHFC programs require approved homebuyer education. Our free class gives you the Washington certificate.

2026 loan limits (single-family)

Pierce, King & Snohomish counties: $1,063,750 for conforming and FHA loans. **Most other Washington counties:** $832,750 conforming.

Program terms, income limits and funding change often. Always confirm with a WSHFC-approved lender or the free Washington Homeownership Hotline at 1-877-894-4663.

GET PRE-APPROVED

Your pre-approval *checklist*

Gather these before you talk to your lender. It makes pre-approval fast and your offer stronger.

Income

- ✓ Last 30 days of pay stubs
- ✓ W-2s for the last 2 years
- ✓ Tax returns for 2 years (if self-employed or commission)
- ✓ Military: latest LES and VA Certificate of Eligibility

Assets

- ✓ Last 2 months of bank statements, all pages
- ✓ Retirement or investment statements
- ✓ Gift letter if family is helping with the down payment

Identity

- ✓ Driver's license or state ID
- ✓ Social Security number
- ✓ Current address and 2-year address history

Credit

- ✓ Check your credit and fix errors early
- ✓ Keep card balances under 30% of limits
- ✓ Know your monthly debts (car, student loans, cards)

Don't do these until after closing

- ✗ Open new credit cards or finance a car or furniture
- ✗ Change jobs or switch to self-employed without talking to your lender
- ✗ Move large sums of money or make big cash deposits you can't document
- ✗ Miss any payments, or co-sign a loan for someone else

OFFER TO KEYS

Winning the home, *protected*

A strong offer has

- A fresh pre-approval letter
- A price backed by recent comparable sales
- Clean, clear terms and a realistic closing date
- The right contingencies for you

Common contingencies

- **Inspection:** time to inspect and negotiate repairs
- **Financing:** protects you if the loan falls through
- **Appraisal:** protects you if the home appraises low
- **Title review:** make sure ownership is clean

After mutual acceptance

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENS
Days 1–3	Earnest money to escrow · schedule inspection · lender orders appraisal
Days 3–10	Inspection and repair negotiations · review title and HOA documents
Weeks 2–4	Appraisal · underwriting · get homeowners insurance
3 business days before closing	You receive your Closing Disclosure. Compare it to your Loan Estimate
Closing week	Final walk-through · sign at escrow · loan funds · deed records · keys!

Wire fraud warning: Scammers send fake wiring instructions by email. Before you send money, **always call your escrow officer at a number you already know** to confirm. I will never email you new wiring instructions.

NEXT STEPS

Ready to go from start to *keys?*

- **Join the free homebuyer class.** Two evenings on Zoom, live Q&A, plus your Washington certificate. fromstart2keys.com/class
- **Book a free 1-on-1 buyer plan.** We'll map your budget, programs and timeline.
- **Get new homes sent to you** the day they hit the market. fromstart2keys.com/search

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